Chapter 1 · Story

Maya arrives late. The room has already decided why.

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



A fictional story. A real question about people.

What would you do?

Leo is assigning the opening shift. What is his most informative next move?

A Ask Maya about today and check her availability.

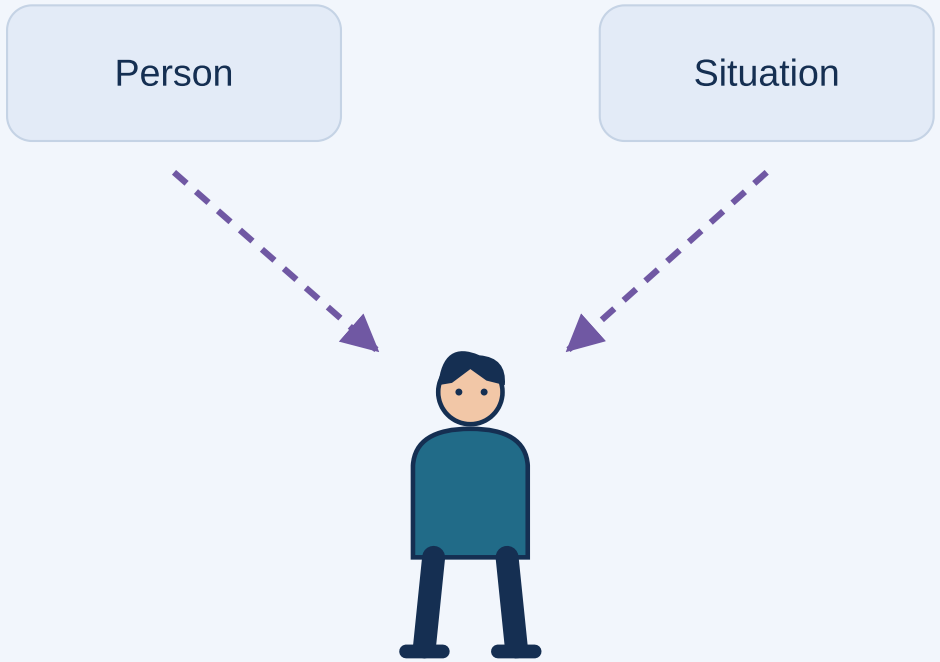
B Use today’s lateness as the main sign of reliability.

C Ignore today and assume she will arrive on time.

Suggested answer: A. Asking Maya about the delay lets Leo investigate the obstacle and plan the shift without ignoring the lateness.

Behavior has more than one author.

- **Person**: tendencies, goals, beliefs, skills
- **Disposition**: a usual tendency, such as patience
- **Situation**: demands, people, available choices
- **Interaction**: pressure can strain usual patience

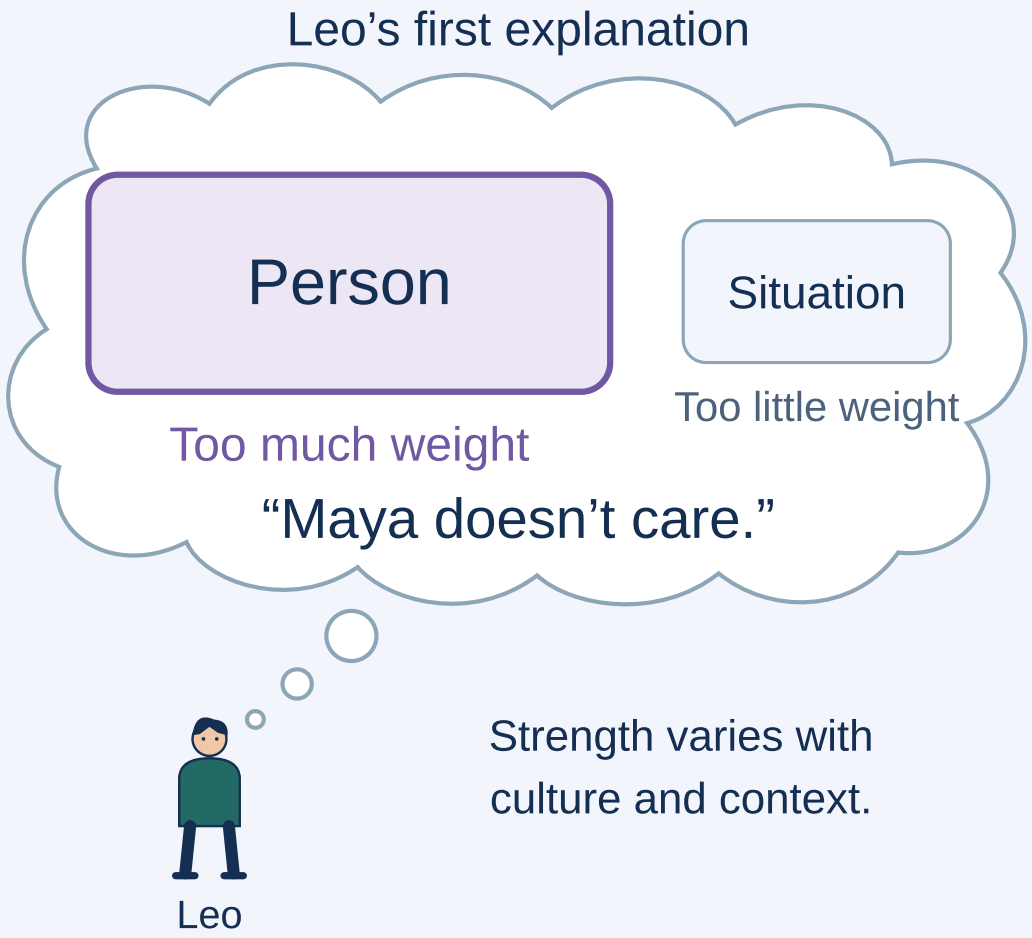


Behavior emerges in context.

Personal qualities and circumstances can both contribute.

Observation is not explanation.

- **Observation**: Maya arrived after the start.
- **Attribution**: Leo explains it as not caring.
- **Fundamental attribution error**: too much weight on the person, too little on the situation.
- **Check**: compare behavior across situations.

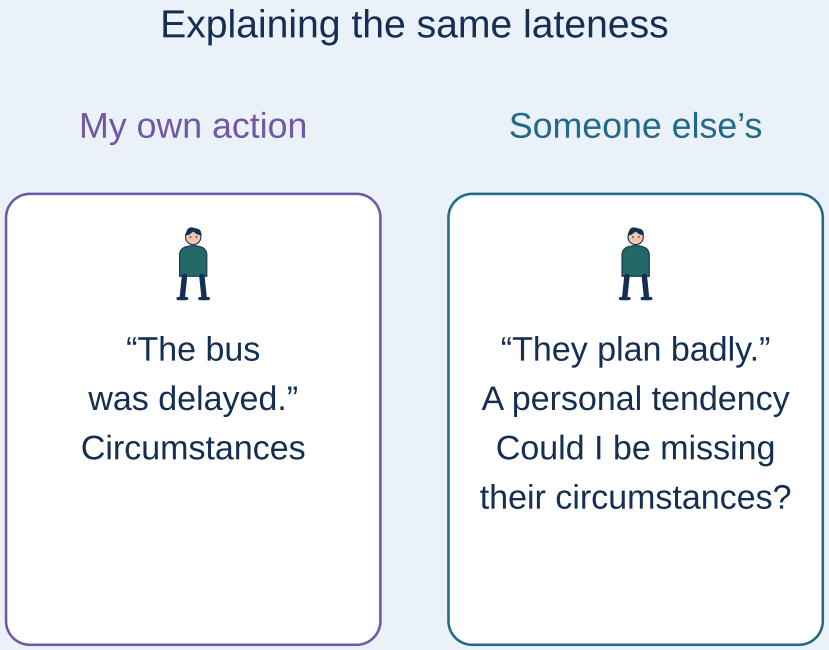


Strength varies with culture and context.

The imbalance is in Leo’s explanation.

What can we really conclude?

An attribution is an explanation of what caused an action. Saying “Maya arrived late” records an observation. Saying “Maya arrived late because she doesn’t care” adds an attribution about her priorities. Attribution research describes patterns in how people explain behavior. It does not establish that personal qualities never matter. Repeated behavior across varied settings is more informative than one episode. Researchers also examine actor–observer differences: differences between how we explain our own actions and other people’s actions. We might explain our own lateness through a delayed bus, but someone else’s through poor planning. Whether that pattern appears depends on the judgment and study design. A bias label alone cannot reveal what is happening in someone’s mind.



A possible actor–observer difference.
The pattern depends on judgment and setting.

Try the idea somewhere new.

A volunteer misses shifts only when the bus service is suspended. What should you test?

A Whether personality alone predicts attendance.

B Whether another travel plan improves attendance.

C Whether the missed shifts can be deleted.

Suggested answer: B. Trying another travel plan tests the suspected barrier while keeping the attendance expectation clear.

Close your notes. Explain it.

> Explain observation versus attribution.

> What would strengthen a personal explanation?

1. An observation records an action. An attribution proposes a cause for that action.

2. An explanation based on a personal tendency becomes more credible when the behavior recurs across varied circumstances and plausible alternatives have been examined.



Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

Carry one idea into your week.

Choose a mildly frustrating encounter. Write the action, your first interpretation, two alternatives, and one respectful question that could clarify it.

Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.



Take the question into a different setting.